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About the Author

Edward Verrall Lucas, (1868 – 1938) was an English humourist, essayist, playwright, biographer, publisher, poet, novelist, short story writer and editor. Born to a Quaker family on the fringes of London, Lucas began work at the age of sixteen, apprenticed to a bookseller. After that he turned to journalism, and worked on a local paper in Brighton and then on a London evening paper. He was commissioned to write a biography of Bernard Barton, the Quaker poet. This led to further commissions, including the editing of the works of Charles Lamb. Lucas joined the staff of the humorous magazine Punch in 1904, and remained there for the rest of his life. He was a prolific writer, most celebrated for his short essays, but he also produced verses, novels and plays.

Glossary:

Brittany – a region on the coast of North–West France

St. James' Street, King Street – well-known commercial streets in London

bloatocrat – a fat and rich person of high station – a term coined by E.V. Lucas by blending the words 'bloated' and 'aristocrat'

electrified – shocked by something unexpected

crescendo – progress towards a climax

congealed – thickened as if frozen (through fear etc.)

smothered – suppressed

nonchalantly – unconcernedly, coolly

glibly – smoothly but not sincerely

note of hand – promissory note

rectitude – honesty, good behaviour

farthing – as low as a paisa

baize – coarse woollen material

guile – cunning, deceit

indelible – cannot be rubbed out or removed

*The phrase 'dree this weird' is from old English. It means 'to put up with one's fate'.

1. Choose the most appropriate answer for the following questions:

a. 'Tight Corner' means a _____.

i. difficult situation
ii. crowded corner
iii. tragic incident
iv. fierce fight

b. Barbizon refers to a _____.

i. kind of paint
ii type of architecture
iii. region in Britain
iv. French school of painters